

UNITED LINUX

A coalition of Linux vendors promises to bring some order to the increasingly chaotic Linux distribution market



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Packaging and marketing a Linux ‘distribution’ is a bit like selling bottled water. Take something that is freely available, add value to differentiate your distribution from the rest, create a brand and then hope that your intended audience shifts their loyalties. But unlike bottled water, the exercise of building a distribution goes beyond mere superficial branding and packaging. Linux distributions tend to be judged by the ease with which they install, their adherence to standards, the simplicity with which they can be customised and maintained, as well as the quality of support and availability of upgrades and bug-fixes provided by the distribution maker once installation and deployment is complete.

Today, over 200 Linux distributions are fighting for a share of the market, each one targeted at a unique set of deployment scenarios and end users. Mandrake and Lycoris (earlier called Redmond Linux) are clearly targeted at the desktop user, Debian is for the austere security-conscious GNU enthusiast and RedHat and SuSE for the enterprise user. The ‘freedom’ to choose from a large number of Linux distributions does have a frustrating aspect since distributions go their own way in matters such as mandating the location of system files, startup scripts and configuration tools. These differences have also necessitated distribution-specific certification.

The announcement of a new consolidated Linux distribution—one that brings together four frontline Linux distribution vendors and called rather ambitiously ‘United Linux’—is heartening. The four vendors are Caldera, SuSE, Turbolinux and Connectiva—the number is expected to increase as more vendors

join the coalition. Though RedHat and Mandrake are not yet a part of the United Linux coalition, the announcement has been greeted with hope and relief from industry heavyweights such as IBM, HP, Computer Associates, Borland and SAP. Designed to be an enterprise-class, industry-standard distribution, United Linux is being promoted as a single, stable and uniform platform for application development, certification, and deployment allowing Linux vendors, Independent Software Vendors and Independent Hardware Vendors to support a single high-value Linux offering rather than multiple different versions.

This bodes well for desktop Linux users who have to battle with the fact that each distribution has its own proprietary packaging standards for binaries. RedHat, Mandrake and SuSE use the rpm (RedHat Package Manager) to distribute applications but a SuSE rpm won’t install cleanly on a RedHat or a Mandrake system. If this broad coalition of vendors can work towards addressing and resolving these issues, United Linux would be a significant catalyst in the widespread acceptance of Linux.

Many years ago, Caldera, one of the partners in the United Linux initiative, released a delightful Linux distribution that allowed the user to play tic-tac-toe during the install. The idea that a Linux install could be as easy as tic-tac-toe was revolutionary for those times. Today most distributions, with their increasingly improving ability to detect hardware and configure drivers, have matured to an extent that ease of installation is no longer a stumbling block. It is time now to move on to life after tic-tac-toe and how United Linux performs there will decide the future of Linux, whether United or not. ■

Gurunandan Bhat teaches at Goa University and works with Synapse—a Goa-based non-profit organisation working in the area of Information Technology and Media. He has been an avid Linux enthusiast since 1993